

AFRICA, SOUTHERN CENTRAL

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SOUTHERN CENTRAL AFRICA is made up of seven countries that form part of the African mainland, and the islands of Madagascar and Comoros in the Indian Ocean. Farming is still an important source of income in these countries, but major deposits of minerals such as diamonds, copper, uranium, and iron have led many people to move to the towns and cities in search of work. A variety of tribal groups, each with its own language, customs, and beliefs, lives in the southern central region.

Physical features

Although lowlands fringe the coast, most of the region lies 400–1,500 m (1,200–4,500 ft) above sea-level. The landscape includes the Namib and Kalahari deserts in the west and centre, dry savannah and woodland, and humid, subtropical forests in the north.



Acacia trees, Madagascar



Regional climate

Most of the region lies in the tropics, where the climate is always hot, but there are two seasons: wet and dry. Rain is heavy in the wet season. Most of Botswana and Namibia has a semi-arid climate, and much of Namibia is desert. Eastern Madagascar has a tropical wet climate.



Namib Desert

The Namib Desert extends 1,900 km (1,100 miles) in a narrow strip from southwestern Angola, along the Skeleton Coast of Namibia, and down to the border of South Africa. Although it rarely rains, the climate on the coast is humid with cold, morning fogs. Sand dunes reach down to the edge of the Atlantic and the only practical means of transport is the camel.

Savannah

Much of the region is covered by grassland, or savannah. The most common trees in these areas are thorn trees, especially acacias. They are suited to the dry conditions and grow on the edges of the Kalahari and other semi-desert regions.

Women's role

The traditional role of African women was to look after the home and bring up the children. Many were also expected to cultivate the crops, and some built their own houses. Today, many women in southern central Africa have additional responsibilities, because their husbands are away working in mines and cities. Despite the domestic power of women, few have official jobs or own property.



Zimbabwean woman with her baby

